

1 Introduction

This paper examines how academic economics incentivizes young scholars and thereby shapes the values and goals of the next generation of professional economists. Talking with young economists entering academia and with their peers about their career prospects, one cannot fail to note their obsession with publication in the Top Five journals, henceforth T5. Faculty meetings about hiring, promotion, tenure, and prize committee discussions assess candidates by the number of T5 articles they have published or have in the pipeline and the rapidity with which they were generated. Research proposals are often appraised by their potential to generate T5 publications.

The T5 journals are: *The American Economic Review*, *Econometrica*, the *Journal of Political Economy*, the *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, and the *Review of Economic Studies*. These “general interest” journals publish papers on a broad range of topics. They are classified in the T5 based on aggregate proxies of journal influence. Assessing researchers based on proxy measures is now common across fields. The use of Impact Factors¹ is one such example. Originally devised as an advisory system for library purchasing decisions, it has now morphed into an assessment system widely used in many fields.² Proxies of aggregate journal performance such as the Impact Factor do not assess the creativity or value of any individual paper, but only assess the scale of subscribership of the publication in which a paper appears and the company it keeps.

Publication in the T5 journals has become a professional standard. Its pursuit shapes research agendas. For many young economists, if a paper on any topic cannot be published in a T5 outlet, the topic is not worth pursuing. Papers published in non-T5 journals are commonly assumed to have descended into their “mediocre” resting places through a process of trial and failure at the T5s and are discounted accordingly. This mentality is not confined

¹Impact Factors are assessed by Web of Knowledge, a scientific citation indexing service produced by the Institute for Scientific Information that advises library acquisitions.

²See Bertuzzi and Drubin (2013)

to the young. Habits formed early are hard to break. Pursuit of the T5 has become a way of life for experienced economists as well. Falling out of the T5 is a sign of professional decline. Decisions about promotions, recognitions, and even salaries³ are tied to publication counts in the T5. Relying on the T5 to assess productivity rewards pursuit of publication counts in the “proper” places and not the development of coherent bodies of research.

To a certain degree there is a strong case for relying on the T5 signal. The profession has grown in size and has become more specialized. There is a demand for certification of quality which publication in the T5 is used to meet. Publication in a highly-rated general interest journal is now considered a proxy for the likelihood that a candidate publishes highly cited general interest papers. In this paper, we demonstrate that readership and citation of a paper and aggregate citations to a journal in which the paper appears are far from the same thing.

The T5 standard has become increasingly difficult to attain. [Card and DellaVigna \(2013\)](#) document that the amount of space available in T5s has remained roughly constant during the period 1990–2012.⁴ At the same time, the number of submissions to the T5 and the length of submitted papers have greatly increased⁵ with concomitant growth in rejection rates and delays in the refereeing process.⁶ Editors now tend to use more referees than in the past. The acceptance rates at T5 journals declined from 15% in 1980 to 6% in 2012.⁷

Economists with established reputations and in highly ranked departments are increasingly not publishing in T5 or field journals⁸ and are increasingly posting papers online in influential working paper series, which are highly cited, but not counted as T5s. This practice likely dilutes the quality of the T5 signal.

The declining acceptance rate and the reliance on the reports of multiple referees (and

³See Table 7 of [Gibson et al. \(2014\)](#). Economics faculty in the University of California system face salary penalties for not publishing in the T5.

⁴See Online Appendix Figure [O-A31](#) for a summary of [Card and DellaVigna \(2013\)](#)’s data.

⁵[Card and DellaVigna \(2013\)](#)

⁶[Ellison \(2002\)](#)

⁷[Card and DellaVigna \(2013\)](#).

⁸[Ellison \(2011\)](#)

concomitant scrutiny and delay) might suggest a rise in the quality of the T5 filter. But it also raises some potentially worrisome issues, which we address in this paper.

We examine the influence of T5 publication on promotion and tenure decisions in academic economics. We analyze data on tenure-track faculty hired by the top 35 economics departments in the U.S. between the years 1996-2010. The top 35 is assessed based on an average of the US News rankings assigned to economics departments during the years 2008, 2010, and 2015. The chosen period gives sufficient time to assess the early impacts of papers and yet is recent enough to describe the current professional environment.

We assess the degree to which tenure decisions are influenced by publication in the T5. We estimate the probability of receiving tenure in the first spell of employment and by the seventh year of tenure-track employment. We supplement this analysis with estimates from duration analyses that show that publishing three T5 articles is associated with a 310% increase in the rate of receiving tenure, compared to candidates with similar levels of publications who do not place any in the T5. Candidates with one or two T5 articles are estimated to experience increases in the rate of receiving tenure of 80% and 230% respectively, compared to those with the same number of non-T5 publications. The estimated effects of publication in non-T5 journals pale in comparison. For the same number of citation counts measured ten or more years after tenure, publication in the Top 5 remains a strong determinant of tenure probabilities and transition rates to tenure.

We explore heterogeneity in the tenure-generating power of the T5 with respect to department quality. Requirements for T5 publication decline with department quality and the impact on tenure of T5 publication increases with declines in department quality as measured by faculty publications. Publishing in the T5 is the most effective means of improving one's chances of obtaining tenure in all of the top 35 U.S. economics departments.

There are differences in rates of tenure by gender, although they are not precisely determined due to our small sample size for women. For men, two T5s is more than enough to get a 50% or higher probability of attaining tenure in the first spell. It takes three for a

woman, but this is only a point estimate and its standard error is big.

After documenting the potency of publishing in the T5, we examine the validity of this filter using citation counts as a measure of validity. While T5 articles are highly cited, so are articles published in non-T5 journals. Many non-T5 articles are better cited than many articles in T5 journals.⁹ Numerous influential papers are published outside of the T5. Indeed, many of the most important papers published in the past 50 years have been too innovative to survive the T5 gauntlet.¹⁰ Many of the 20 most cited RePEc papers were not published in the T5.¹¹

In principle, insisting that scholars publish in general interest journals works against the growing trend in academic economics toward specialization and Balkanization. However, it flies in the face of current scholarly practice. Leading scholars in most fields largely publish in non-T5 field journals. In addition, non-T5 journals generally dominate T5 journals in terms of citations in the top journals within most subfields of economics. The T5 journals typically rely on field specialists to review papers submitted in their fields. Scholars who themselves primarily publish in, read, and cite papers from non-T5 field journals appraise the quality of prospective candidates for promotion and hiring using their T5 publications.

The tenure of editors is long, especially at house journals whose editors are mostly, if not exclusively, affiliated with a single department. Low turnover in editorial boards creates the possibility of clientele effects surrounding both journals and editors, whereby authors, in an effort to increase their chances of publication, choose to conduct research that caters to the policy and/or methodology preferences of editors. Given the large rewards associated with publishing in the T5, and the consequences of failing to do so, it is not implausible that

⁹See, e.g., Hamermesh (2018), who makes this point. We build on and extend his analysis.

¹⁰Akerlof (2018) suggests that the T5 journals often endorse “safe research” that extends the boundaries of a field slightly, but does not advance it by much. This is likely a consequence of the peer review process, which engenders an inherent conservatism. See also the discussion in the AEA symposium linked here: <https://www.aeaweb.org/webcasts/2017/curse>.

¹¹RePEc (www.RePEc.org) stands for Research Papers in Economics and is a major source for rankings of citations in the profession. According to the RePEc website: “...over 2,000 archives from 99 countries have contributed about 2.6 million research pieces from 3,000 journals and 4,600 working paper series. Over 50,000 authors have registered and 75,000 email subscriptions are served every week.”

such clientele effects are both prevalent and large in magnitude.

It is well-documented that journals in economics tend to publish work by authors who are connected with the journal’s editors (see [Brogaard et al., 2014](#), [Laband and Piette, 1994](#), and [Colussi, 2018](#)). We corroborate this literature by estimating *incest coefficients* that quantify the degree of inbreeding in publications in the T5. Editors are likely to select the papers of those they know. Network effects are empirically important.¹²

Whether this practice capitalizes on the benefits of using inside information that improves journal quality as measured by citations or whether it is unproductive cronyism is much-discussed.¹³ The evidence on this issue is not conclusive, but it appears to favor the story of net benefits to insider knowledge. Although evidence on the source of the observed network effects is inconclusive, the mere existence of such network effects gives cause for concern. The T5’s tendency to publish work written by authors who are connected to the editorial board has the possibly unintended but real effect of penalizing authors who lack such connections. Unconnected authors are thus worse-off due to network effects that are biased against them, regardless of whether such network effects stem from favoritism or insider knowledge. However, this paper does not address in depth the larger question of the value of using citation counts to judge productivity and the self-referential nature of groups within economics who referee and cite each other’s papers and tend to exclude outsiders.¹⁴

Given the many adverse consequences associated with the current reliance on the T5, we believe the discipline should reevaluate its current strong weighting of T5 publications as a measure of research achievement and as a filter for tenure and promotion decisions. The case for change is bolstered by the inadequacy of the T5 in predicting the quality of an article.

¹²[Colussi \(2018\)](#) is a recent study.

¹³[Laband and Piette \(1994\)](#) find that articles with author-editor connections are indeed more likely to be published, however, these articles also tend to attract higher citations on average. [Brogaard et al. \(2014\)](#) estimate that authors publish 100% more papers in a journal when the journal is edited by a colleague, compared to periods when such department-editor networks do not exist. They also find that connected articles generate 5% – 25% more citations than unconnected articles on average.

¹⁴See [Kapeller et al. \(2017\)](#)